

MANDAR DEODHAR

It was in 2010-11 that Zoya and Reema started writing together. By then, they had already known each other for over a decade, but Zoya hadn't made a great impression at their first meeting around 1997, they recall. She was there to audition for a role in Kaizad Gustad's *Bombay Boys*, and Reema was the one taking the audition. Zoya admitted to her that she was "really bad", and Reema agreed: "I don't think you are getting the job either". Not that Zoya wanted it in the first place. She too, like Reema, was an assistant director (AD). The two eventually ended up working as ADs on that film, and then on *Dil Chahta Hai* (2001). Later, Zoya would be an executive producer on *Lakshya* (2004) and Reema the first AD. When it came to Reema's directorial debut in 2007, *Honeymoon Travels Pvt Ltd*, Zoya would act as executive producer (EP). After that, the relationship just blossomed. For Zoya's own first film two years later, *Luck By Chance* (2009), Reema's constructive feedback helped. "We gave each other our first scripts. Wherever we were stuck, we wrote each other's scenes," says Zoya of the initial collaboration. "It was super-seamless."

In more than a decade since, the two have helmed a number of successful projects. Currently, they, along with Excel Entertainment and Salman Khan Films, are producing *Angry Young Men*, a documentary on Salim Khan and Zoya's father Javed Akhtar who together redefined Hindi cinema and screenwriting in the 1970s-80s, delivering story after story that tapped into the zeitgeist of the time. That dynamic association, however, ended in 1987 with *Mr. India,* the last film they wrote together. Ask Reema and Zoya what it takes to sustain a creative collaboration, and Zoya tells you, "My dad says if you are agreeing on everything, there's no point in having the person as your partner. And if you are disagreeing, then it is too cumbersome to get anything done. It has to be a healthy mix of both."

The pair has certainly achieved that mix, and a few writing rules have helped along the way. A usual day for them, says Zoya, starts early in the morning. They meet at either of their places to work and "try to stay out of office", says Reema. There's a good deal of talking and discussing, and then writing. "After lunch, I love a siesta. I can never do